We did not have a day of peace. It is the story of many Kashmiri couples. Constant fear is the dominant feeling in all Kashmiri households.

We were so happy when a child was born. We named our son after the legendary poet Mirza Ghalib. We had a dream to see our son Ghalib grow up. I could spend very little time with him. After his second birthday I was implicated in the case.

What do you want him to grow to be?

If you mean professionally, a doctor. Because that is my incomplete dream. But most importantly, I want him to grow up without fear. I want him to speak against injustice. That I am sure he will. Who knows the story of injustice better than my wife and son?

While Afzal continued talking about his wife and son, I could not stop recollecting what Tabassum told me when I met her outside the Supreme Court in 2005 during the appeal stage of the case. While the rest of Afzal's family remained in Kashmir, Tabassum dared to come to Delhi with her son Ghalib to organize the defence for Afzal. At a tiny roadside tea stall outside the Supreme Court New Lawyers Chamber, she chatted in detail about Afzal. She told me how much he enjoyed cooking. One image has remained with me, a precious private moment from their life together—he asks her to sit on a chair near him in the kitchen, and ladle in one hand and a book in the other, reads out stories to her as he cooks.

If I may ask you about the Kashmir issue—how do you think it can be solved?

First let the government be sincere to the people of Kashmir and initiate talks with the real representatives of Kashmir. Trust me, the real representatives of Kashmir can solve the problem. But if the government considers the peace process as one of the tactics of counter insurgency, then the issue is not going to be solved. It is time some sincerity is shown.

Who are the real people?